

What Is This Room For?

Decide what you want your place to do. Then find what's fighting it.

Most advice about your home starts with cleaning. This starts one step earlier, with the question that makes cleaning worth doing: **what is this place actually for?** Answer that and half the decisions make themselves.

HOW TO USE THIS

Four parts, one sitting, about 45 minutes. **Everything is a tick box** — you are choosing from a list, not filling in blanks. Walk around while you do it. Part 4 turns your ticks into a dated list, which is the only part that changes anything.

Tick **three to five**. **No more**. Five things you actually want beats fifteen you'd like. If everything is a goal, nothing is.

PEOPLE — WHAT SHOULD BE POSSIBLE HERE

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Someone can drop by without warning and I'm not embarrassed | ☐ I can have one or two people over for dinner |
| ☐ I can have six to ten people over | ☐ Someone can stay the night comfortably |
| ☐ We can watch a movie or a game together properly | ☐ Family can visit and not feel like they're in the way |
| ☐ It's just me, and that's the point
A home that works for one person is a real goal, not a lesser one. | |

FEELING — HOW IT SHOULD READ WHEN YOU WALK IN

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Hotel
Clear surfaces, nothing personal out, everything squared up. | ☐ Calm and plain
Few things, all of them chosen. |
| ☐ Warm and full
Books, colour, things with a story. Full is fine; chaotic isn't. | ☐ Bright and open
Light is the whole effect. |
| ☐ Low and cosy at night
Different light after dark than before it. | ☐ Workshop
Tools out because they're used. Order that serves making things. |

FUNCTION — WHAT YOU NEED TO BE ABLE TO DO

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Work or study here without clearing a space first | ☐ Cook real food without running out of counter |
| ☐ Sleep well — the bedroom does one job | ☐ Exercise without moving furniture |
| ☐ Keep a hobby set up, or set it up in under five minutes | ☐ Find anything in under a minute |
| ☐ A guest can find a glass, a towel, or the bin without asking | |

SURFACES — THE ONE ABOUT STUFF

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Free horizontal spaces
Tables and counters are for using, not for storing. | ☐ Everything owns one place , and I know where it is |
|---|--|

☐ The **floor is clear** — nothing lives on it that isn't furniture

☐ I can **wipe a whole counter** without moving nine things first

WRITE THEM DOWN

Say each one as a sentence starting "*I want...*" and write it at the top of Part 4. Out loud, if you can stand it.

Wanting something specific is what makes the rest of this work — and most people have never once said what they want their home to *do*.

Walk into each room and stand there for a moment. Pick the job, then tick what's working against it. Skip rooms you don't have.

The way in

Its job: **land** — keys, shoes, post, bag, all with somewhere to go.

FIGHTING IT

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Nowhere to put keys , so they move around | ☐ Post piles up here, or somewhere worse |
| ☐ Shoes have no edge or mat to live on | ☐ Bag or coat ends up on a chair or the floor |
| ☐ It's the darkest spot in the place | |

Living room

Its job: pick one — **having people in** · **watching something** · **reading and sitting** · **all three, in shifts**.

FIGHTING IT

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ The coffee table is storage , not a surface | ☐ Seating faces the screen when the job is talking, or doesn't when it's watching |
| ☐ There's nowhere to set a drink from where people actually sit | ☐ One overhead light , on or off, nothing in between |
| ☐ Furniture is too big for the room
A table that shrinks when no one's coming is worth more than a bigger room. | ☐ There's a pile with no owner — it's been there weeks and it's nobody's |
| ☐ You can't tell what the room is pointed at
Every room has a focal point. If it's the television by default, that was a decision made for you. | |

Kitchen

Its job: **cook and clear**, without a tidy-up before you can start.

FIGHTING IT

- ☐ **No clear run of counter** big enough to actually work on
- ☐ The **bin is in the wrong place** — you carry rubbish across the room
- ☐ You keep **moving things to reach** the things you use daily
- ☐ **Not enough light on the counter** where you chop
- ☐ Things live on the counter that are used **less than weekly**
- ☐ **Something's in the sink** most of the time
- ☐ The **dining table has become a desk**, or a shelf

Bedroom

Its job: **sleep**. Anything else in here is a guest.

FIGHTING IT

- ☐ There's a **chair that is really a laundry pile**
- ☐ Work or a screen **lives in here**
- ☐ **No lamp** — the only option is the ceiling light
- ☐ Clean and dirty clothes **aren't clearly separate**
- ☐ Nothing to put a glass or a phone on **within reach of the bed**
- ☐ Too much light in the morning, or the wrong kind at night

Bathroom

Its job: work for you daily, and be fine for a guest with no warning.

FIGHTING IT

- ☐ Everything you own is **out on the surfaces**
- ☐ Nowhere for things to **dry**
- ☐ No bin
- ☐ A **guest couldn't find a clean towel**
- ☐ A bulb is out, or all of them are **unflattering**

Where you work

Its job: **start in under a minute** — even if it's a corner of the table.

FIGHTING IT

- ☐ You have to **clear it before you can start**
- ☐ **Cables** are a daily negotiation
- ☐ **Light comes from behind you**, or from nowhere
- ☐ You have to **clear it before you can eat**
- ☐ The **chair is wrong** and you know it
- ☐ Paperwork has **no home**, so it lives in view

The car

Its job: it's a room you own. Treat it like one.

FIGHTING IT

- ☐ Things live in it that **should have come inside days ago**
- ☐ There's no **bin or bag** for rubbish
- ☐ A passenger would have to **move something** to sit down
- ☐ The boot is **long-term storage**
- ☐ You don't know where the **documents** are

THE PATTERN YOU'LL NOTICE

Most of what's fighting you isn't dirt, and it isn't a shortage of space. It's **something without a home**, or **furniture doing a job it wasn't meant for**. Both are decisions, not chores — which is why cleaning never fixed them.

This gets its own part because it changes how a place feels more than anything else you can do in an afternoon, and almost nobody tells you. It's also the most renter-friendly thing on this page — nearly all of it unplugs and comes with you.

TICK WHAT'S TRUE

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ A room where the ceiling light is the only light | ☐ Bulbs of different colours in the same room
One warm, one blue-white. It reads as "wrong" without anyone identifying why. |
| ☐ Nothing you can turn down in the evening | ☐ You can't read comfortably in the chair you read in |
| ☐ A bulb has been out for more than a week | ☐ A room you avoid and can't say why
Check the light first. It's usually the light. |

WHAT FIXES IT

- ☐ **Two lamps beat one ceiling light.** Light from two low points instead of one high one is most of the difference between a room that feels like a room and one that feels like a corridor.
- ☐ **Match your bulb colour across a room.** Warm for living and sleeping, brighter and cooler where you work or chop. Consistent within a room matters more than which you pick.
- ☐ **Get one light you can turn down** — a dimmable bulb, or just a small lamp you use instead of the big light after dark.
- ☐ **Put light where the task is**, not only in the middle of the ceiling. The counter, the desk, beside the chair, next to the bed.
- ☐ **Replace dead bulbs the day they go.** A dark corner quietly becomes a place things get dumped.

This is the part that matters. Everything above is noticing; noticing changes nothing on its own.

PICK FIVE. LEAVE THE REST.

Go back through your ticks and choose the **five** that would most change how the place works. Not the easiest five, and not all of them. A list of five with dates gets done. A list of thirty is a mood.

I want... (your three to five from Part 1)

THE FIVE THINGS

WHAT I'M GOING TO DO

DONE BY

WHO'S CHECKING

DON'T SKIP THE THIRD COLUMN

Name an actual person and tell them. Not for accountability theatre — because a date you told nobody about is a wish. Ask them to check whether you *started* on time as well as whether you finished. Starting is the part that goes wrong.

Notes

Most of this costs nothing. Moving a bin, turning a chair, deciding where the post goes, taking one thing off a table. The spending version of this advice is a different and much less useful guide.

Renting doesn't disqualify you. Lamps, bulbs, where furniture sits, what goes on a surface, and what a room is for are all yours. Paint and fittings aren't the part that changes how a place feels day to day — the rest of it is.

If you can't pick a job for a room, that's the finding. A room with no job becomes the room everything gets put in. Giving it one — even a modest one — is usually the single highest-value decision in the house.

Do this again when something changes. A new flatmate, a new job, a baby, a move. The place should be for whatever your life is now, and it quietly stops being that without anyone noticing.

One sitting, then stop. If you find yourself on hour three, you've turned a 45-minute decision into a project. Five things, dates, done.

*Nobody ever asked you what you wanted your
home to do. It's a fair question, and you're
allowed an answer.*

Mr. Life Manager — practical systems for running an adult life

Free to use, copy, and teach from — with credit. Not for resale.